

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 362

By Mitchell

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor Jeff Zentner, author of *In the Wild Light*.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly recognize those accomplished Tennesseans who have devoted their lives to creative endeavors, thereby enriching the lives of their fellow citizens; and

WHEREAS, one such estimable individual is Jeff Zentner of Nashville, an author of young adult fiction whose career is a testament to the possibilities that lie at the confluence of talent, hard work, integrity, and devotion; and

WHEREAS, a standout among Mr. Zentner's novels is *In the Wild Light*, which is set in East Tennessee and chronicles the life of Cash Pruitt, a young man being raised by his Papaw and Mamaw after losing his mother to an opioid addiction; and

WHEREAS, Cash dodges drug dealers and watches out for his best friend, Delaney, as he spends the summer mowing lawns while she works at the Dairy Queen; when Delaney secures full scholarships for both of them to an elite prep school in Connecticut, Cash must grapple with his need to protect and love Delaney and his love for the grandparents who saved him and the town he would have to leave behind; and

WHEREAS, selected as a *New York Times* Notable Book, *In the Wild Light* is an examination of grief, found family, overcoming adversity, and becoming more than you ever thought you could be; Jeff Zentner's characters, setting, and compelling prose expertly convey the trials, loves, and aspirations of a young man from the mountains; and

WHEREAS, books such as *In the Wild Light* that show the complex truth of East Tennessee and its people are a balm and a bolster to those from the region and a needed diplomat to the rest of the world; and

WHEREAS, Jeff Zentner is the author of *The Serpent King*, also a *New York Times* Notable Book; *Goodbye Days*; *Rayne & Delilah's Midnite Matinee*; his debut for the adult market, *Colton Gentry's Third Act*; and a young adult novel in verse, *Sunrise Nights*, coauthored with Brittany Cavallaro; and

WHEREAS, among other honors, he has won the American Library Association's William C. Morris Award, the Amelia Elizabeth Walden Award twice, the Muriel Becker Award, and the International Literacy Association Award, and he has been longlisted for the Crook's Corner Book Prize and twice for the Carnegie Medal; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Zentner is a two-time Southern Book Prize finalist and was a finalist for the Indies Choice Award; he was selected as a *Publishers Weekly* Flying Start and an Indies Introduce pick. His books, which have received twenty-one starred reviews, have been translated into fifteen languages and have been featured on *The Today Show*, *Good Morning America*, and in *Vanity Fair* and *People Magazine*; and

WHEREAS, before becoming a writer, he was a musician who recorded with Iggy Pop, Nick Cave, and Debbie Harry; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Zentner has done much to contribute to the literacy, entertainment, and well-being of readers the world over, and it is fitting that he be honored; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize and honor Jeff Zentner, author of *In the Wild Light*, extending our best wishes for much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.